







UP CLOSE
(shot by Robert Capa):
(clockwise from left) Ernest Hemingway in Idaho, US (1941); US troops at Omaha Beach on D-Day in Normandy, France (1944); Republican soldiers of the International Brigade in Madrid, Spain; a soldier writing a letter in Madrid (1936)

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ROBERT CAPA COLLECTION OF HUNGARY, CAPA CENTER, BUDAPEST

Dispatches from War

PHOTOGRAPHY

LEGENDARY PHOTOGRAPHER **ROBERT CAPA** CHANGED THE WAY WE LOOK AT AND CHRONICLE CONFLICT

A young woman and man decide to start working together in Paris in the early 1930s. Both are Jewish—she's German, he's Hungarian—both are leftists, and they begin to explore the possibilities of using photographs and writing in tandem to report on the momentous events unfolding around them. They decide that their names, Gerta Pohorylle and Endre Friedmann, are too cumbersome and they arrive at a pen name—they decide to call themselves 'Robert Capa', with Gerta, now calling herself 'Gerda Taro', representing 'Capa' as an agent when selling their work to the newly launched picture magazines.

The invention of the Leica 35mm camera has now taken off, allowing people to take photographs with these small cameras rather than the cumbersome large format ones prevalent till then. Gerta/Endre/Capa take their Leicas and head for Spain, where the conflict between Loyalists and Republicans is turning into a full-fledged civil war. Having now become lovers as well as partners, both take pictures under the name of Robert Capa, and the exact authorship of the photographs from this period is difficult to pin down. Tragedy strikes in July 1937 when Gerda is killed in a road accident in the melee of battle.

ROBERT CAPA'S pictures were the first ones that turned blurred photographs into valid recordings of a time

Shattered and heartbroken, Endre now becomes the sole inhabitant of the persona of Robert Capa.

An overview of the career tells us that Friedmann/Capa worked as a photographer/photojournalist for about 18 years, from the age of about 22 till his death at the age of 40; from mid-1937 onwards, all the photographs are solely his. These 18 years were also the blood-drenched hinge between the first third of the 20th century and the latter two-thirds, years that changed the course of human history and which still affect us today in deep ways. Capa witnessed and covered the Spanish Civil War, the Sino-Japanese War, the Second World War in Europe, the first Arab-Israeli War and, finally, the Indo-China war that segued into the Vietnam War. Capa's photographs changed the way we looked at war and how we looked at the world. While many are beautifully still and sharp, Capa's pictures were the first ones that turned blurred and slightly out-of-focus photographs into valid recordings of a time, giving photography an immediacy and primacy that television's audio-visual moving pictures still find hard to dislodge.

Do visit the show at Museo Camera and see the actual prints if you can. A lot of the famous Capa images are on display, but also many that aren't seen so often: a train in the China conflict with a huge Nazi swastika on the roof of a carriage to warn off Japanese bombers that the bogey was carrying Nazi advisors; a line of GIs snaking across the Sicilian landscape; an American soldier in the Tunisian desert that could easily be a more recent image from Iraq or Syria; a Vietnamese peasant tilling the paddy fields with bullocks as an army column passes behind him. This last image was among those that Capa made just before he stepped on the landmine that killed him when he was barely 40. By then, he had worked the shutter button and the film advance lever on his Leicas seventy thousand times to record one of history's most violent periods from right up close. ■

Ruchir Joshi

(The exhibition will be on until the end of January, at Museo Camera, Gurugram)